

STARTER

Field-by-Field Application Walkthrough

Germany - Schengen Tourist Visa (Type C)

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

Before you start

A German Schengen Tourist Visa (Type C) is applied for at the German embassy or consulate with jurisdiction over your place of residence - in many countries, through an outsourced visa application centre (commonly run by VFS Global or TLScontact), though the decision itself is always made by the German mission, not the outsourced centre. It's decided under the shared EU Visa Code. Gather the following before you begin:

- Valid passport, issued within the last 10 years and valid for at least 3 months beyond your planned departure from the Schengen area
- The completed national visa application form
- A biometric photo meeting current specifications
- Travel medical insurance meeting the Schengen minimum coverage requirement
- A detailed day-by-day itinerary and proof of accommodation for every night
- Financial evidence covering your trip - see the Financial Requirements Overview (Essential tier)
- If you're being hosted personally: a Verpflichtungserklärung from your host (see below) - not a letter you write yourself

THE VERPFLICHTUNGSERKLÄRUNG - START THIS EARLY

If a friend or family member in Germany is hosting and/or funding your visit, German practice generally expects a formal Verpflichtungserklärung (declaration of commitment) rather than an informal invitation letter. Critically, your host obtains this themselves, in person, at their own local Ausländerbehörde (foreigners' registration office) in Germany - not something they can simply write and email you. This takes time to arrange, so your host should start the process well before your intended travel dates.

Section-by-section

1. Personal details

Name, date of birth, nationality, and passport details exactly as they appear in your passport.

2. Purpose and itinerary

- Main purpose (tourism, visiting family/friends, business) and a specific day-by-day plan
- If you'll visit other Schengen countries too, list them - Germany is only the correct consulate to apply at if it's your main destination or first point of entry

3. Accommodation and travel

Hotel bookings for every night, or your host's Verpflichtungserklärung and address if staying with someone, plus your round-trip transport arrangements.

4. Financial information

Your income, savings, and how you'll fund the trip - see the Financial Requirements Overview for what German missions specifically look for.

5. Previous Schengen visas and travel history

Any previous Schengen visas from any member state, refusals, or overstays - checked against the shared Visa Information System (VIS).

6. Pay the fee and give biometrics

Pay the visa fee and give fingerprints and a photo at your appointment, unless reusing biometrics from a Schengen application within the last 59 months.

7. Submit supporting documents

Submit your insurance certificate, itinerary, accommodation proof, financial evidence, and Verpflichtungserklärung if applicable, at your appointment or as instructed by the application centre.